What Your Father Would Want a Future Caregiver to Know, Written Down Now

Four prompts to turn ordinary conversations into notes, learn what makes his day enjoyable, check your assumptions against what he actually says, and start a preferences page that is built to be revised.

Where you are

Your father is well and nobody is talking about caregivers. But you've noticed how much you would have to guess if someone else ever had to look after him for a week, and you would rather ask him now, over coffee, than find out later that nobody wrote down how he likes his eggs.

This guide gives you four ChatGPT prompts to organize what you already know and to see what you don't know yet. It is preparation, not an assessment. Use only information you have permission to share, with names removed. The AI organizes and drafts; it does not diagnose, assess safety, or decide. Bring clinical questions to a clinician, and call emergency services for an emergency.

What you'll have at the end

You have a first version of your father's preferences in his own words, you know which of your assumptions he corrected, and the page has a date and a plan to update it.

A one-page preferences draft: How I like to be addressed, My ordinary day, Food and routines I enjoy, People and activities that matter to me, How I like to be spoken to, and When to ask me again.

Before you start

- A relaxed hour or two with your father, over a meal or a drive, when nobody is rushing.
- A few things you think you know about his preferences, to test against what he says.
- A notebook or your phone to jot down his phrases. That's the whole kit.

PROMPT 1

Turn a conversation into questions worth asking

WHY THIS MATTERS

You're not interviewing him. You're having a conversation that happens to leave notes behind. A handful of open questions makes that easier than a checklist ever will.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

A sense of what you would like to know, and a couple of topics he enjoys talking about.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> I want to learn more about my father's everyday preferences while things are calm, so the family would know how to look after him well if that were ever needed. He is independent and I don't want this to feel like a form. Here are the topics I'd like to cover and a few things he likes to talk about:
>
> [PASTE YOUR TOPICS]
>
> Give me twelve open-ended questions I could ask over a meal or a walk, grouped under: A GOOD DAY, MORNINGS AND EVENINGS, FOOD AND SMALL PLEASURES, PEOPLE AND PASTIMES, and HOW HE LIKES TO BE TREATED. Phrase them the way a son or daughter would actually speak, not the way a clinic would. Don't ask about illness, decline, or end of life.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

Questions that would get him telling stories, not giving answers.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Pick five and ask them this week. Write down his phrases, not your summary.

PROMPT 2

Learn what makes an ordinary day good

WHY THIS MATTERS

The details that matter in care are usually small: the radio station, the second cup of coffee, the walk after lunch. He may not think they are worth mentioning. Your notes will show you they are.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Your notes from the conversations, as close to his words as you got them.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here are my notes from talking with my father about his ordinary days, with his own words where I caught them:
>
> [PASTE YOUR NOTES]
>
> Organize them into a plain description of his day under: HOW HE STARTS THE DAY, MEALS AND WHAT HE ENJOYS, HOW HE FILLS THE AFTERNOON, EVENINGS AND WINDING DOWN, and PEOPLE HE SEES OR CALLS. Keep his phrasing in quotation marks wherever I gave it to you. Then

> list the small details he mentioned in passing that someone caring for him might overlook. Finally, name the parts of the day I didn't get to, so I know what to ask next time.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

The small details list. That's the gold.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Fill one of the gaps the next time you see him.

PROMPT 3

Check what you assumed against what he said

WHY THIS MATTERS

Families carry old facts around. He hated church as a young man; he goes every week now. He always drank tea; he switched to coffee a decade ago. The point isn't to catch anyone out. It's to find out which of your facts are current.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

The list of things you thought you knew, and your notes from his answers.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Before talking with my father, I wrote down what I believed about his preferences. Then I asked him. Here are both:
>
> [PASTE WHAT YOU ASSUMED]
>
> [PASTE WHAT HE ACTUALLY SAID]
>
> Make a three-column table: WHAT I ASSUMED, WHAT HE SAID, and CONFIRMED, CORRECTED, OR NOT YET ASKED. Where he corrected me, keep his version and note mine as background. Where I made an assumption and never asked, mark it NOT YET ASKED and turn it into a question for next time. Then tell me which preferences seem to have changed over the years, based only on what we have both said, so I remember that the rest can change too.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

The corrected rows. Each one is a detail a future caregiver would have gotten wrong.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Tell him which of your assumptions were out of date. It's a good conversation.

PROMPT 4

Start a preferences page built to be revised

WHY THIS MATTERS

This isn't a final document. It's a first draft with a date on it, written so it is easy to change. That's what keeps it honest a year from now.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

The results of the first three prompts.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is what I've gathered about my father's preferences from our conversations:
>
> [PASTE THE RESULTS OF PROMPTS 1 TO 3]
>
> Write a one-page draft in the first person, as if he were speaking, using only what he said or confirmed. Headings: HOW I LIKE TO BE ADDRESSED, MY ORDINARY DAY, FOOD AND ROUTINES I ENJOY, PEOPLE AND ACTIVITIES THAT MATTER TO ME, HOW I LIKE TO BE SPOKEN TO, and WHEN TO ASK ME AGAIN. Under the last heading, suggest three ordinary life events after which the family should check whether anything has changed, such as a move or a change in his health. Add a line at the bottom for the date and who he is happy to have see this. Leave out anything medical or dietary that a clinician would need to confirm.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A page he would recognize himself in.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Read it to him, change what he wants changed, and put a note in your calendar to revisit it next year.

Give his preferences a home

A page of preferences is a good start. The care interview keeps them alongside the rest of your father's situation in a Family Care Profile, so when something does change, the family isn't starting from a blank page.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›